Loves Me Not

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/45553894.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Hanahaki Disease, Mutual Pining, Unrequited Love, but - Freeform, Not Actually Unrequited Love, Angst, Pining, Pining: the Fanfiction, Angst with a Happy Ending, Graphic Depictions of Illness, throwing up, And Weird Lung Feelings, Hurt/Comfort, Best Friends to Lovers, Read a/n for further disclaimers, Idiots in Love, Love Confessions

Language:
English

Stats:
Published: 2023-03-07 Words: 3,418 Chapters: 1/1

Loves Me Not

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/45553894.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Hanahaki Disease, Mutual Pining, Unrequited Love, but - Freeform, Not Actually Unrequited Love, Angst, Pining, Pining: the Fanfiction, Angst with a Happy Ending, Graphic Depictions of Illness, throwing up, And Weird Lung Feelings, Hurt/Comfort, Best Friends to Lovers, Read a/n for further disclaimers, Idiots in Love, Love Confessions

Language:
English

Stats:
Published: 2023-03-07 Words: 3,418 Chapters: 1/1

Loves Me Not

by ResFlower

Summary

Suddenly, Catra is so wrong. There's no way she can keep it down. It feels like throwing up, but it's yellow carnation petals that litter the ground and the counter. Her eyes widen—she's never released that many petals at one time. It's definitely getting worse. She looks up, tears in her eyes from coughing, and Adora is watching her horrified. Catra bites her lip and looks down. She can't take watching the realization Adora will have that she's pathetically pining for her, that she has been for ages.

She feels Adora's hand fall on her shoulder as she comes around the other side of the kitchen. "You're in love with someone?"

She looks up and Adora's eyes are curious and open, a hint of fire blazing through them.

"Yes." It would be stupid to deny it. Everyone knows what it means when this happens.

Adora looks torn, eyes wide as she searches for words. "And they don't—this person? They don't—"

"She doesn't love me back, no," Catra says flatly.

OR

The Hanahaki Disease AU literally no one on this planet wanted.

Notes

TRIGGER WARNING:

Hanahaki Disease is a fictional disease where a person suffers from flowers growing in their lungs when they suffer from unrequited love. Given this, there will be some gross and graphic descriptions that involve throwing up flowers. I tried not to make it gross for grossness'sake but like, there is only so much you can do with the ick factor when the starting premise is throwing up flowers from longing lol.

Regardless, hope y'all enjoy!

Thanks to yagirlStatic for the naming help.

See the end of the work for more notes

"This tea shop isn't the best I've been to," Adora whispers into Catra's ear like somehow the owner is going to catch her talking shit and kick them out.

Catra's lips twitch into a smile. "Why's that, huh?" She humors her best friend, leaning her elbow forward on the table they're sitting on.

It isn't odd for Catra and Adora to be out in Bright Moon trying out something new when the two have a day off that happens to coincide. Adora's taken to exploring new tea shops lately. It isn't Catra's thing but for her sake, she'll tolerate it.

"This tea doesn't taste like much of anything," Adora makes a face, as she looks at her mug.

Catra sighs. It's a moment she'll come to ponder on for the rest of her life. She's not sure what it is about Adora sitting in that tea shop if it was the way her blue eyes warmed Catra inside out, or the way she always complained about tea but loved to drink it, or maybe the innocent smiles and furtive looks she'd send Catra.

But that was the exact moment Catra knew she'd been in love with her best friend. It hits her like a hammer to the chest, her bones rattling with the newfound knowledge that snaps into her heart. She bites her lip to keep a sound of surprise from coming out.

"Hand over the tea, let me see." She takes the distraction to shove down the realization as quickly as it bubbles up.

Adora rolls her eyes but gives the tea to Catra, their fingers brushing as Catra takes it. "Tell me it tastes anything like a rose. I dare you. I have half a mind to get my money back." She huffs.

Catra tips the mug towards her and she's surprised by just how floral it tastes. Not necessarily rose flavored, but honestly, Catra's always been bad at distinguishing between flowers.

"Uh, Adora that tastes super flowery . You sure your tastebuds work"? She teases, mostly to cover up her confusion. Adora usually has a good handle on these things and Catra is the one left unable to discern light flavors.

Adora snatches back the mug and takes another sip while looking at the mug. "It tastes like hot water , Catra!"She complains before looking around. "Let me shut up before someone hears."

She rolls her eyes and ignores the way her heart flutters as Adora glances around, blonde hair up in a half ponytail. After their tea is done, Catra says goodbye and bundles up to face the cold. Catra feels like she has something stuck by her molars. She runs her tongue over her teeth and cant quite tell what it is. Catra probably looks ridiculous with whatever face shes pulling. She goes to the bathroom and tugs at what she assumes is some piece of food caught in her teeth.

Instead, she finds a lone white rose petal. Catra stares and stares at it, a sense of dread filling her. "Fuck me."She whispers to herself.

She avoids Adora for a few weeks, and she only coughs up a petal or two in the meantime. It takes her some time to process it~~tha~~t shes sick because she loves Adora and isnt loved in return.

Her doctor says its more complicated than that~~she~~ needs to both be loved *and* believe it~~bu~~t believing it isnt an issue if you dont have love in the first place. And things between her and Adora are painfully platonic. They have been ever since they were kids.

She sighs when she sees her phone light up, the girl in question calling her. When she picks up, Adora doesnt bother saying hi. "Okay , I really dont care if your job is trying to have you chained to a desk. We need to see each other. Its been forever , Catra!"She whines and Catras lips cant help but twitch into a smile.

"Aww. You miss me, princess?" She bites her lip—maybe the nickname is too familiar now.

"Duh, Cat. You're only like my best friend in the whole wide world. And you've been avoiding me." She accuses, not bothering to hide the suspicion in her voice.

"I've just been busy…" She hedges as she picks at the edge of her bedsheets.

"It doesn't feel that way," Adora grumbles. "I'm kind of wondering if you got yourself a girlfriend and decided to ditch me." The words are light-hearted, but it makes Catra hiccup, tiny little lavender petals dance in the air.

"No Dor. We can hang out right now if you like." She makes the offer without really thinking it through but fuck she does miss Adora. She can keep it together in front of her—most of the time, she doesn't even feel the flowers that are slowly blooming in her lungs. She ignores how she's unable to take a truly deep breath, the type that almost hurts from your chest being so full of air.

"Really?" Adora sounds so excited and Catra can't regret her choice.

She nods even though Adora can't see. "Yeah, really. You free?"

"Of course, I am! I'll see you in ten." She hangs up without saying goodbye. Catra can imagine her running through her place and shoving on her shoes before coming over.

Catra brushes her teeth twice and tries to clear her throat as best she can before Adora arrives. By the time Adora leaves, they've made plans to see each other again and Catra has to run to the bathroom, picking out three more petals from her mouth.

Things slowly go back to normal and Catra is better for it. She loves hanging out with Adora, even when she ends up having to deal with

the fallout—namely , keeping from letting out the flowery secret trapped between them. Catra feels confident in her ability to keep the petals from interfering so she barely thinks of them when she sits on Adora's counter as she makes them a quick snack.

"I'm thinking, we could go to the museum. It would be fun, just us two. What do you say?" Adora looks at her with glittering blue eyes and Catra has never felt warmer. She butters her toast. "I feel like the art of friend dates has really been lost you know? I'm so glad we could do this together."

Suddenly, Catra is so wrong. There's no way she can keep it down. It feels like throwing up, but it's yellow carnation petals that litter the ground and the counter. Her eyes widen—she's never released that many petals at one time. It's definitely getting worse. She looks up, tears in her eyes from coughing, and Adora is watching her horrified. Catra bites her lip and looks down. She can't take watching the realization Adora will have that she's pathetically pining for her , that she has been for ages.

She feels Adora's hand fall on her shoulder as she comes around the other side of the kitchen. "You're in love with someone?"

She looks up and Adora's eyes are curious and open, a hint of fire blazing through them.

"Yes." It would be stupid to deny it. Everyone knows what it means when this happens.

Adora looks torn, eyes wide as she searches for words. "And they don't—this person? They don't—"

"She doesn't love me back, no," Catra says flatly . This is the worst possible thing to happen. She doesn't want to deal with Adora's guilt or sadness at having caused this in Catra. Sure, it's not fun and it may very well kill her, but it's not Adora's fault.

"She doesn't—" Adora cuts herself off with a disbelieving snort. "You're sure, Catra? Any woman would be lucky to have you."

"Trust me, I know she doesn't." It's obvious in the way Adora treats her. She sees Catra as a friend—a dear friend, someone she loves platonically, but Adora doesn't love Catra the way she does.

"What are you going to do?" Her voice carries the quiet horror most do when people learn of her condition. She can't really blame Adora for that.

"I'll be alright. I have a doctor and we are managing my symptoms as best we can." She says evenly. "There's not much to do at this point."

Adora bites her lip like she's thinking about something but she doesn't say much just nods. "If there's anything you need from me, Catra. I'm here."

She nods even though Adora's words just make her want to cry. She has in her hands the ability to make it all better. But Catra can't just ask her friend to love her.

As Catra's disease progresses, Adora becomes even closer to her, which ironically makes it worse. Her doctor has advised that if romance is not in the cards and if she's not planning on getting the surgery that could make this all go away, her biggest and best chance of survival is to create some distance from Adora.

It feels impossible to turn Adora down, though. She looks at Catra with those wide eyes telling Catra of a new movie she'd like to see with her or a restaurant she'd like to go to and the word 'no' just dissolves from Catra's vocabulary. She loves Adora so much and the thought of living longer but without her, just doesn't seem worth it. It's a smaller scale of the decision she's made to forgo surgery.

"Hey ."Adora has her ponytail down and Catra gets to run her fingers through her hair. She can almost breathe easily, forgetting that Adora doesn't love her when she's looking at her with soft eyes, her head in Catra's lap as Adora turns to look at her . Catra keeps her fingers rubbing on Adora's scalp and the blonde's eyes flutter for a moment. "I need to focus."She whines, but she still tilts her head toward Catra's attention.

It makes Catra grin. She feels a few petals come up but she clears her throat and swallows them down. It's gross as fuck, but she hates displaying more symptoms than she needs to when Adora is around.

She's clearly not as slick as she thinks she is because Adora's eyes narrow on her as if she can see through Catra. "You don't need to hide it from me."She mutters almost annoyed. Catra bites her lip but doesn't say anything. Adora sighs. "I wanted to talk to you about something."She says cautiously .

Catra moves her arms, letting Adora sit up into a more comfortable position. She mourns the loss of her golden locks thrumming through Catra's fingers, but she's also made anxious by the purse of her lips. That nervousness takes center stage.

"I think you should get the surgery ."She says bluntly . "No one is worth this, Catra."Her voice is almost desperate as she reaches out and grabs Catra's hand.

They'd had the vague contours of this conversation but Adora has never been so forthright on this point.

Catra shakes her head. "Adora. It's my decision, and I've talked with my doctor. I'm not doing it."

"It's selfish."Adora bursts out. "You should think about your life here, Catra. You can love again. It doesn't have to be her or no one." Adora urges.

It's easy for Adora to say, she doesn't understand everything Catra would lose if she went through with the surgery. "It's not just love, Adora." She reminds the blonde. "If I get this surgery I'll lose every part of her. No friendship, no—" She shakes her head, she's already said too much. "It's my decision." She finishes stiffly.

She's not giving up every part of Adora. Maybe if it was just romantic love she'd consider it. But the thought of feeling cold toward Adora is simply not acceptable.

"Fine. It's your decision, Catra." Adora sounds angry, sniffling with hot tears streaking her face. Catra tries to reach out, to comfort her, but Adora shoves back;getting off of the couch. "But I don't have to watch you waste away for a woman who probably hasn't even come to visit you." She spits out angrily.

Catra tries to say something but she can't breathe for a moment, white and red tulips springing out of her mouth. She grabs a bucket she keeps nearby and spits them out, the light taste of pollen on her tongue.

Catra begs for her. "Adora"—

"No. Call me if you decide that you've found something to live for." Adora says resolutely, her eyes burning blue. "I can't watch you do this to yourself." The last whisper is almost apologetic but no less resolved.

She tries to follow Adora but she falls into a coughing fit, her lungs hurt and everything inside her chest is painful. This time a rose stem, thorns and all, claws up her throat.

Adora is gone by the time she's done coughing, leaving Catra in a messy pile of white and red. Maybe she is an idiot for not letting Adora go.

It happens faster than Catra thinks it will. At this point, her lungs feel like there is simply no room for air. Her chest is tight and her breaths become more and more shallow as time goes on. When Adora comes to see her, she coughs, pink camellia flowers spraying out of her mouth. Fucking figures.

Her eyes are red from crying as she looks at Catra for the first time in a few months. "I'll kill them." She swears as she brushes a few of the petals off of Catra's chest and onto the floor. "I'm sorry I left. I was angry and stupid. I came as soon as I heard."

Catra doesn't have much time left, it's plain as day. She'd been hoping to see Adora again and it seems like at least she'll have that wish granted before she died.

Catra snorts. "No, Adora. It's fine." She brings her hand up to touch Adora's cheek. This time her heart pangs. Adora is so beautiful and kind, of course, she would be here for her.

"It's not fine, Catra. You're dying because someone is being that biggest fool on the planet." She shakes her head. "There's still the surgery." She suggests desperately through her tears. "You can—you can just be *alive*, Catra. Love someone who wants you back." Adora begs.

She shakes her head before Adora even finishes speaking. "I can't—I won't. It's too late anyways." The doctors had told her when her last chance had been and she'd let it go. She couldn't imagine not loving Adora, not even having warm feelings of friendship toward the blonde. She wouldn't be herself without them, they'd been a part of her since she was just a kid.

"That's not fair! Catra, what about everyone else? What about me." Her sobs turn into a whimper and she's resting her head on Catra's chest. If Catra wasn't actively dying, this would surely kill her. Adora crying over her this way, heart wrenching sobs that Catra would do anything to stop.

She runs her hand through the blonde's hair, even though it takes a tremendous amount of effort. "You're going to be okay. It's going to be alright." She soothes. Adora is social and put together, not the mess that Catra is. She'll grieve and live out her life, find someone who loves her as much as Catra does. It won't be hard, Adora could make anyone fall in love with her.

"No, Catra. I'll never recover. There's nothing left if you're gone." She cries and then she coughs, a single marigold petal floating above them before landing on Catra's chest. Adora looks stricken. "You weren't supposed to see that." She murmurs lowly.

Catra turns and coughs over the side of the bed, petals and stems pouring out of her, whole flowers forcing their way up her raw throat until she manages to get it under control.

She glares up at Adora. "Go tell them. Whoever it is. Look at me, Adora! Don't do this to yourself." She's begging and finally, tears fall from Catra's eyes. She knows she's being a hypocrite but she doesn't want this for Adora.

"You're one to talk." Adora's blue eyes are furious as she narrows her gaze on Catra. "Besides, I know she's in love with someone else." Adora bites her lip. "She's willing to die over it. Even if the person she loves doesn't love her back." She eyes Catra meaningfully and Catra just stares, dumbfounded.

Does Adora? Could she? And then she breathes deep and Catra is pretty sure she can smell colors she can breathe so deep.

"Adora." She marvels as she stares up at the blonde. But she's still tense and Catra realizes she hasn't really said anything. Fuck. She pulls herself up to sit, and she's never felt fucking better. "I love *you.* It's always been you."

Adora coughs up another petal. "No, but it can't be you've been—me? But I love you so much. That's not unrequited love." She protests.

"It's not enough for your love to be requited, you have to know it is." Catra offers quietly.

Adora's eyes widen and Catra can tell the next breath is easier, her breath heaving deep as she looks at Catra. "You love me?" Her voice has the quiet wonder that Catra can feel vibrating in her chest.

"Of course, I do." She bites her lip. "I've loved you so long that I don't know who I am without it."

Adora's eyes are so blue, the love between them filling the air like the flowers that used to hurt their chests. "I'm going to kiss you."

She leans forward, stopping right before her lips touch Catra's. She lets her eyes close and bridges the gap between them, a groan escaping her lips when she's finally kissing Adora. It's everything she'd hoped for and more. Adora's arms are wrapped around her and she grabs onto Adora's arm for leverage, to press closer to the blonde.

"I love you." She whispers against Catra's lips. "I realized when you ~~the~~ the day I found out you were in love with someone." Her hands run through Catra's hair, pulling her impossibly close. "I couldn't imagine why anyone wouldn't want you. How anyone could reject the best person I know." She laughs but it turns into an almost sob. "I always loved you but I never contextualized it as romantic until then."

She nuzzles Adora's cheek. "I didn't know until way later too. But one day it just clicked and ~~it~~ just felt impossible to think you felt the same."

They sit there, nuzzled into each other's necks just breathing. Adora smells like sunshine and clean-cut grass and everything that's good. She's almost falling asleep just holding the blonde when she feels her stiffen and pull back.

"Wait. You're ~~you~~ you're better right?" Her eyes are wide and her smile bright as she lucks Catra over.

"You just noticed?" She raises an eyebrow. "You're better too, aren't you?" She can't help but check.

A shadow passes over her face. "Yeah, but you were worse off." Her eyes are shimmering with tears again. "But you're okay now."

Catra makes a show of taking a deep breath, opening her diaphragm, only clean air whistling through her air passageways. "Good as new." Catra had forgotten what it felt like to breathe easy.

Adora practically tackles Catra and she falls backward onto what was going to be her deathbed only a few moments ago. She crushes Catra to her chest and she's reminded of the familiar sensation of not being able to breathe.

"Adora." She laughs. "I still need to breathe."

Adora plops over the other side of the bed. "Sorry." She clamors close again, placing a soft kiss on Catra's lips. She doesn't think she'll ever tire of how that feels. Adora's lips are soft and Catra wants to kiss her forever. "I'm just so happy you're alright."

"I'm a little better than alright now." Instead of the pain in her heart—and the ache in her lungs—she just feels love. Pure and unadulterated, unmarred by the twinge of heartache that has been there since she realized what Adora means to her.

She presses her forehead to Adora—her best friend but now more—and she feels a sense of peace she's never felt. Catra commits to just living in the moment and breathing Adora in.

End Notes

I've always thought about doing this AU at some point and I decided to finally just do it. I know it's not for everyone, but I enjoyed writing it. I'm happy to hear y'alls thoughts and I'm curious how people feel about the trope in general. As far as I can tell, there aren't that many SPOP fics that touch on it.

Kudos and comments, make me a happy clam. You can find me on Twitter and Tumblr (I accept prompts here if you are nice about it lol).

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!